

C-k. The cut text goes into a kill ring buffer. You can paste whatever you have removed using *C-y*. You can cycle through the text that has been removed by repeatedly using *M-y* after *C-y*. Consider the following text:

When you have a question about Emacs, the Emacs manual is often the best starting point.

If you place the cursor before “about” in the above sentence, and press ‘*M-d*’, it will remove “about”. You can now see the value of the kill-ring using *C-h v* (describe variable), and it will prompt you with the message ‘Describe variable:’, where you can enter *kill-ring*. You will see an entry for “about”. Now, place the cursor after ‘question’ and press *M-d* again, and “Emacs” will be removed. If you again check the kill-ring value, you will see an entry for “Emacs”.

You can now move the cursor to any location in the buffer, and press *C-y*, and it will paste “Emacs”. If you then press *M-y*, it will paste ‘about’ which was the text that was cut before “Emacs”. This way, you can cycle through the kill ring buffer.

To select a region of text, you first need to mark the starting position with the cursor using *C-space*. You can then use any of the navigation commands to highlight the text that you want. You can either cut the marked region using *C-w*, or copy it using *M-w*. This will get copied to the kill-ring. You can then paste the text to any buffer. You can also select the entire buffer using *C-x h*.

Formatting text

It is good to have text within 80 columns and 25 rows (80x25), not just for readability, but to avoid making any assumptions about the users’ screen size. If you have a really long sentence or paragraph, you can reformat it using the *M-q* shortcut from anywhere in the sentence or paragraph.

You can transpose two characters using the *C-t* shortcut. For example, if you have misspelt ‘emacs’ as ‘emcas’, you can place the cursor on ‘a’ and type *C-t* to swap the letters ‘a’ and ‘c’ to get ‘emacs’. You can transpose two words using the *M-t* command. For example, if you have the phrase ‘morning good’ in a buffer, and you type *M-t* anywhere on the word ‘morning’, it will swap the words to give you ‘good morning’. You can also swap lines and sentences using the *C-x C-t* and *M-x transpose-sentences* commands, respectively.

If you would like the first letter of a word in upper case, you need to place the cursor on it, and key in *M-c* to make the first letter capital. You can turn all those letters from the cursor location to the rest of the word into capitals using the *M-u* command. For example, if you have the word ‘sentence’, and you place the cursor on the letter ‘t’, and hit *M-u*, the result will be ‘SENTENCE’. To make all the characters lower case, you can use *M-l*. You can turn the entire previous word into capital letters using the *M - M-c* shortcut. Similarly, to make the previous words either upper case or lower case, you can use *M - M-u* and *M - M-l* commands, respectively.

Info

You can read manuals written in the *Info* format inside GNU Emacs. When you type *M-x info*, it opens up a menu with the built-in documentation available from the ‘*Info*’ files. The *Info* mode is mostly used to read hypertext manuals. You can use *Tab* and *Shift-tab* to navigate through the available links. Since the contents are in a buffer, all the basic navigation commands are applicable. To exit from *Info*, you can use *q* (quit).

You can press the *return* key on a link to open its contents. For example, when you click on ‘Emacs FAQ’ it opens ‘The GNU Emacs FAQ’ contents. The following sections are listed in its buffer:

- Menu
- FAQ notation
- General questions
- Getting help
- Status of Emacs
- Common requests
- Bugs and problems
- Compiling and installing Emacs
- Finding Emacs and related packages
- Key bindings
- Alternate character sets
- Mail and news
- Concept index

Suppose, you hit the *return* key on ‘FAQ notation’, it will open its contents with the title ‘1 FAQ notation’. If you want to cycle through the headings at this level, you can press *n* (next topic) and *p* (previous topic). If you want to move one level up, to the ‘The GNU Emacs FAQ’, you can use the *u* shortcut.

If you simply want to move to the topmost node (The GNU Emacs FAQ), you can use the *t* shortcut. For example, if you were in the section ‘3.1 I’m just starting Emacs; how do I do basic editing?’ and you pressed ‘*t*’, it will take you to the topmost section – ‘The GNU Emacs FAQ’.

You can move to the previous node that you visited using the *l* shortcut. You can also explicitly specify the node you want to move to using the *g* shortcut. For example, if you are in the ‘1 FAQ notation’ page, and you pressed *g*, it will then prompt you with the message, ‘Go to node:’. You can then type ‘Extended’ and hit *Tab* to auto-complete to ‘Extended commands’, which is one of the links in the page.

You are encouraged to try the built-in info tutorial available by pressing *h* in the ‘info’ buffer.

Help

You can read manual pages inside GNU Emacs using the *M-x man* command followed by the *return* key. Suppose, you try this command from the *scratch* buffer, it will then prompt you with the message ‘Manual entry:’. You can then input *ls* (list directory contents), and it will open a new buffer and window titled ‘*Man ls*’ with the contents of the manual entry for the *ls* command.

From the *scratch* buffer, you can scroll forward the other